1962, Beijing assessed that the United States would not intervene, and that India was not interested in negotiations. There was also a domestic political dimension, specifically Mao's keenness to overcome the disasters of his landmark economic programme, the Great Leap Forward. Two days after a major conference of the Chinese leadership in August 1962, military preparations began in earnest. In September, China occupied the Thagla ridge in NEFA, technically north of the McMahon Line according to treaty maps but south of the watershed, and thus Indian-claimed. The news of this caused a political furor in New Delhi, and evicting China became a question of Indian resolve. Sporadic firing broke out in late September, and after a final exchange of diplomatic notes, China decided on 6 October to inflict a punishing blow in the eastern sector. On 10 October, an advancing Indian patrol was decimated by Chinese forces at Namkachu. On 13 October, Nehru's remarks about the situation were misreported in the press as a promise to "throw out" the Chinese, leading to the *People's Daily* concluding the next day that a 'massive invasion of Chinese territory by Indian troops . . . seems imminent'. [108]

After approval by China's Central Military Commission on 18 October, the Chinese attack began in earnest on 20 October. The first line of Indian defences in the eastern sector crumbled, and a decision was made to fall back from Tawang. On 16 November, the PLA began its second phase of operations, which in three days broke Indian resistance in both western and eastern sectors. On 19 November, Nehru desperately wrote twice to US President John F. Kennedy requesting accelerated and urgent assistance, including air power. [109] But by the time the United States requested further details, China had indicated its intent of a ceasefire and a withdrawal in the eastern sector. Significantly, it appears that many of Nehru's key aides and other Indian foreign policy officials were kept in the dark about Nehru's desperate requests to Washington. [110] By 21 November China unilaterally announced a ceasefire and withdrew to its 1960 claim line in the west and to the McMahon Line in the east. The reasons for Beijing's ceasefire and withdrawal are unknown but were probably a combination of logistic unpreparedness for a sustained presence in the eastern sector (particularly